

Chicago Tribune



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TUESDAY, MARCH 25, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

'They've got everlasting money, bro'

Chicago Archdiocese alleges conspiracy to file false sex abuse claims against defrocked priest

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

A West Side man was talking to his imprisoned cousin in 2013 when he allegedly floated the idea of adding him to a string of bogus sexual abuse allegations filed against defrocked Chicago Catho-

lic priest Daniel McCormack, court records show.

"I think I want to put you on these cases now," the man told his cousin, who at the time was serving a three-year term for a gun conviction.

"Hell yeah," the cousin, Ahmond Williams, allegedly responded. "I

need some ass free money too. ... As long as (McCormack) ain't got to touch me for real, I don't give a (expletive)."

That conversation recorded on a prison line 12 years ago was included in an unusual new lawsuit filed by the Archdiocese of Chicago on Monday alleging a group of mostly West Side residents, including a convicted murderer and others associated with violent street gangs, conspired for years

to bring false allegations of sexual abuse by McCormack — often ranked among the most notorious child sexual abusers ever employed by the church — in order to win millions of dollars in legal settlements.

The co-schemers were caught on tape calling the false claims "licks," a common street term for a robbery or ripoff, according to the suit. Once they got paid, many of the co-schemers burned through

their settlement quickly, buying cars, taking trips to Las Vegas or Miami and even hosting street parties where videos posted on social media allegedly showed them throwing cash in the air.

The new legal push is not an attempt to clear McCormack's name, and the accusations of false claims do not address his past victims. McCormack pleaded

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STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Balloon release for slain teen

Marie Reynolds, left, great-aunt of Kaylah Love, 16, hugs a teen during a balloon release for Love outside Manley Career Academy High School in Chicago on Sunday. Kaylah Love was found murdered last week in Horan Park in Chicago about a mile from her home. She was a sophomore and an aspiring chef. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

ANALYSIS

Trump's moves on Greenland misfire

By Jeffrey Gettleman
and Maya Tekeli
The New York Times

For more than 150 years, U.S. officials have been trying, as President Donald Trump puts it, to "get" Greenland.

The idea came up in the 1860s, then again before and after the world wars. In a way, the timing couldn't be better than now, with Greenlanders reexamining their painful colonial history under Denmark and many itching to break off from Denmark, which still controls some of the island's affairs.

But Trump seems to have overplayed his cards — big time.

His decision, announced this weekend, to send a high-powered U.S. delegation to the island — apparently uninvited — is already backfiring. The administration tried to present it as a friendly trip, saying that second lady Usha Vance, the wife of Vice President JD Vance, would attend a dogsled race this week with one of their sons and that Michael Waltz, the national security adviser, would tour a U.S. military base.

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ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

First week of spring

Eleven-year-old Keyon, left, plays basketball with his 13-year-old cousin Armani Allison near the intersection of South Laffin and West 63rd streets during the first week of spring Monday in the Englewood neighborhood of Chicago.

Mayor taps ex-alderman as Springfield lobbyist

Mayor Brandon Johnson has named former Ald. John Arena to lobby on behalf of Johnson's administration in Springfield. The progressive Northwest Side politician lost a bitter reelection fight in 2019. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Tony's Fresh Market workers to vote whether to go union

Over the next three days, 2,400 cashiers, deli clerks, meat cutters, bakery workers, pastry decorators, florists and other grocery store staff will decide whether Tony's Fresh Market will become a union shop. **Business**

Reports of ICE at schools continue

District officials' emails show panic and misinformation

By Nell Salzman
Chicago Tribune

The Trump administration's crackdown on immigration has led to a string of concerned reports from principals and parents to Chicago Public Schools officials, according to a review of internal communication from district security personnel.

On Jan. 24, a mistaken CPS report of two U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement officers at Hamline Elementary School on the South Side spurred nationwide panic. The two officers were later confirmed to be Secret Service, not ICE — both agencies are part of the U.S. Department of Homeland Security. A security video showed the agents approached the school in a relatively benign manner, despite high levels of fear that day.

A look at emails from district officials in the weeks since the mistaken ICE report demonstrates that both panic and misinformation around ICE in schools has continued since

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Trump plans have fed workers on edge

Leases canceled on federal office space in Chicago area

By Brian J. Rogal
Chicago Tribune

The administration of President Donald Trump forged ahead this month with plans to shrink the federal government's national real estate footprint, canceling hundreds of office leases across the country and proposing to sell off many properties.

In the Chicago area, as of this week nearly 200,000 square feet of leased federal office space had been canceled, including space that houses the Midwest regional headquarters for the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission on West Jackson Boulevard. A federal lease on a building in northwestern suburban Hoffman Estates that stores documents and artifacts from the administration of former President Barack Obama — essentially serving as Obama's Presidential Library — was also canceled.

And many federally owned buildings in Chicago — including the John C. Kluczynski

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